

erie (mutual trust and friendship) to chance or serendipity. Camaraderie is created and maintained by informal communication, and is a key pillar of culture.

Remote culture is largely built by empowering people to fill their social quota outside of work, in local neighborhoods and communities, and then bring that culture to work. Too many leaders are looking to replace onsite lunches with virtual lunches and happy hours, instead of empowering workers to look to their communities to further define who they are as people.

8. Are communication expectations documented in a single source of truth?

Absent communication guidelines, colocated organizations generally default to meetings as the catch-all for communicating about work. Great remote organizations create and document expectations and suggestions around communication, both formal and informal. For transitioning organizations, don't wait until you have implemented a central workspace tool to start articulating communication expectations. Even a boring solution such as requiring all work-related meetings to have an agenda attached to the calendar invite can usher in new ways of thinking.

9. Does each team member call/collaborate with their own equipment?

A hybrid call is one that has a mix of participants in the same physical room, together with others who are remote. Hybrid calls should be avoided, as it's better to have everyone on a level playing field for communication and discussion. If a hybrid call must happen, however, everyone should use their own equipment (camera, headset, screen) even if they are physically sitting in the same room.

10. Do you have a documented and defined in-person strategy?

Humans are social creatures, and research has shown that there is value in in-person interactions. While there are tremendous advantages to operating a 100% remote company, leaders should consider being intentional about planning in-person elements, even if they're optional for team members.

Quarterly or bi-annual retreats, annual company-wide gatherings, in-person onboarding cohorts, and budgets for ad hoc in-person moments are just a few examples. Great remote organizations recognize that people do not need to spend hours each day commuting to see one another every 24 hours, but budgeting for strategic in-person gatherings are useful for bolstering culture and building rapport.

11. Do you hire, praise, and promote on values alignment and results?

Great remote organizations actively work against proximity bias by utilizing praise and promotion tactics rooted in values alignment. A boring solution to encourage this is the use of a promotion document which requires a manager detail how an individual has exemplified company values.

12. Do you fund individual workspaces and reimburse for out-of-home office use?

Great remote organizations recognize that there are more than two places to work. While "the office" and "home" are two options, the third space is vast. Platforms such as Codi, Gable, and

Switchyards exist to support these arrangements. Enabling team members to submit for reimbursement for coworking or external office space indicates that an organization is so sure of its remote-first workflows that it is comfortable empowering people to work from a variety of spaces.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

{{% include "includes/courseragitlabremotecourse.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/tips.md

How it works at GitLab

{style="max-width: 50%;"}</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 552 850 585" data-label="Text">
<p>For GitLab, being an all-remote company did not start as an intentional decision. It was a natural evolution as our first team members started choosing to work from home.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 601 896 669" data-label="Text">
<p>Traditional, on-site companies often take processes, camaraderie, and culture for granted and allow it to develop organically. But in an all-remote company, you have to organize it. This can be hard to do at first, but then as you scale it becomes more efficient, while the on-site, organic approach can quickly fizzle out.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 685 885 735" data-label="Text">
<p>Now that we're the world's largest all-remote company with over 1,300 team members in 65+ countries, we've learned a lot at GitLab about how to collaborate effectively and strengthen our culture, all while working remote. Take a look at how we make it work.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 751 403 769" data-label="Text">
<p>{{< youtube "GKMUs7WXm-E" >}}</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="120 784 428 801" data-label="Section-Header">
<h2>We facilitate informal communication</h2>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 816 896 884" data-label="Text">
<p>Making social connections with coworkers is important to building trust within your organization. One must be intentional about designing informal communication when it cannot happen more organically in an office. All-remote companies need to facilitate these interactions for their teams.</p>
</div>

Learn more about enabling informal communication in an all-remote company.

Handbook, goals, and documentation

Remote work is also what led to the development of our publicly viewable handbook, which captures everything you'd need to know about the company. If you can't tell, we like efficiency and don't like having to explain things twice.

Each department and team's quarterly goals, or "objectives and key results" (OKRs), are also clearly documented in our handbook for visibility across the company. We check in on these goals monthly, so there's as much transparency as possible around what each team is accomplishing.

Our approach to documentation also helps with onboarding new team members, because everything they need to know is in one place.

We also have an extensive onboarding template and we host a GitLab 101 for new hires to ask questions.

Docs instead of whiteboards

We're often asked, "But how do you whiteboard without everyone physically together?" We use Google Docs for collaboration. Every meeting has a Google Doc agenda, which is used for documenting discussions, decisions, and actions. Everyone in the meeting can add notes at the same time, and we even finish each other's sentences sometimes.

By brainstorming in text instead of drawings, we're forced to clearly articulate proposals, designs, and ideas, with less variance in interpretations. A picture may be worth a thousand words, but it's also open to as many interpretations as there are people viewing it.

With Google Docs, we use indentations to go more in-depth on a given topic. This method retains context for comments, discussions, and ideas, even if someone wasn't present for the original conversation.

Docs instead of water coolers

Documentation also helps with transparency, which is critical to remote work. While decisions made around office water coolers may be familiar in traditional workplaces, input is limited to those present.

Those who are not present feel left out, and you're missing an opportunity to hear different perspectives.

The GitLab way of working is more inclusive. By documenting everything, no one is left out of the conversation and a diverse set of perspectives can be heard, not only from GitLab team members but also from customers and community contributors.

We're transparent about hiring and compensation principles

Hiring

We've published our hiring process, including example screening questions, in our handbook. While this may be unique, we see it as simply staying true to our transparency value. The process shouldn't be a mystery.

Letting candidates know what to expect allows them to focus on whether the role and the company are right for them, while we evaluate that too.

Compensation

As an all-remote organization with team members and candidates around the world, it's also important that we're as open as possible about our compensation principles.

That's why we created a compensation calculator that helps determine compensation for more than 200 regions globally.

Take a look at how our compensation calculator works, and learn more about why we pay local rates.

Country hiring guidelines

Hiring globally as an all-remote company has many advantages, including bringing diversity to our team. But it also poses unique challenges because many countries differ in their rules, laws, and regulations.

Find out more about how we handle this in our country hiring guidelines in the handbook.

We encourage flexibility and balance

Work from anywhere

{{< youtube "BC7Prkm3v3g" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, two GitLab colleagues discuss the benefits of living in a lower cost-of-living environment near friends, family, and community.

At GitLab, when we say our people can work from anywhere, we really mean it. We care about the results of their work, not where it's getting done.

This flexibility often means something different for each person at GitLab.

There are others who join and travel the world with remote co-working and co-living organizations.

Many of our team members appreciate the ability to still be able to work while visiting friends or family away from home.

Even for those who typically work in their home office, this flexibility means they can do things like run errands on a weekday, take their child to school, spend more time with family, or walk their dog during the day.

We have a channel on Slack called office-today where our team members can share photos of their

work location or view on any given day.

Time away from work

It's important to clarify that being able to work from anywhere does not replace the need to take time off of work.

We recognize how crucial it is to build in time when you can mentally take a break from your work, and as a company, we encourage our team members to do that. Learn more about how time off works at GitLab.

> "I work closely with our executive team here, and they have been so supportive and encouraging when family-related conflicts arise. They are constantly reminding me that "family first" is our mantra, and give me ease of mind to take time away when needed. Sid, our co-founder and CEO, told me if it's a beautiful day out and I just want to go enjoy it, I should do that. Moments like these make me so proud to be a part of the GitLab team."

- Cheri, Manager, Executive Assistant

Tips for leaders and other companies

{{< youtube "u0dRWDmYSvg" >}}

In the LinkedIn Talent on Tap video above, GitLab co-founder and CEO Sid Sijbrandij shares advice on managing within a remote workplace. Discover more in GitLab's Remote Work playlist.

Here are some best practices that may help your all-remote team be successful.

Managing your team

- Don't require people to have consistent set working hours or say when they're working.
- Don't encourage or celebrate long working hours.
- Don't encourage or celebrate working on a team member's day off (e.g. a weekend or holiday) unless it is required as part of their job responsibilities, such as direct/indirect customer support.
- Encourage teamwork and saying thanks.
- Learn more about managing a 100% remote team.

Communication

- Encourage people to write down all information.
- Allow everyone in the company to view and edit every document.
- Consider every document a draft, don't wait to share until it's done.
- Use screenshots in an issue tracker instead of a whiteboard, ensuring that everyone at any time can follow the thought process.
- Encourage non-work related communication (talking about private life on a team call) for relationship building.
- Encourage group video calls for bonding.
- Encourage one-on-one video calls between people (as part of onboarding).
- Host periodic summits with the whole company to get to know each other in an informal setting.

Hiring

- Be transparent about your hiring process and practices so that interviewing time can be spent evaluating the candidate's ability to do the job.
- Don't limit yourself to only hiring people who have a passion for remote work. Start by looking for candidates who align with your company values and the role itself.
- Assign new hires a buddy so they have someone to reach out to in their first weeks.
- Define clear goals and performance indicators for each role from the start so that you can measure success once you've hired someone for the role.

Tips for employees

Arguably the biggest advantage of working remotely and asynchronously is the flexibility it provides. This makes it easy to combine work with your personal life, although it might be difficult to find the right balance.

Our team members often share their best advice about working from home, and you should ask your coworkers about what remote work tactics work best for them. Here are some tips you might find helpful:

Find your routine

- You may work better with a consistent workday routine, or you may find that it's best to determine when your waves of peak productivity are, and design your work day and routine around them. These may shift and change depending on the season, holidays, family schedules, etc.
- Take small breaks throughout your working hours to keep your creativity or productivity going.
- If you worked at an office before, you might be missing your default group of coworkers at lunch. Now that you have the flexibility to choose what you do with that time, reach out to a friend and ask them to lunch.

> "I think you need to throw the concept of 'nine to five' out the window and actively experiment to find what schedule lets you make the most of your time. I often find the midday slump to be so real, so if I'm feeling this way I step away for a while and then come back for a few hours in the evening when I generally feel supercharged."

- Tanya Pazitny, Quality Engineering Manager

Balance work and life

- Explicitly plan your time off so that you'll intentionally take time for yourself.
- When you're not working, disconnect by turning off Slack and closing down your email client. At GitLab, this only works if all team members abide by the communication guidelines.
- Enable the "working hours" feature on your calendar so that team members in other time zones know not to schedule meetings during times when you're not working.

Communicate clearly

- Remote teams are less likely to know what's going on in each other's daily lives, so it's important that you're able to express yourself and ask for help when you need it.
- Make the most of your video calls so that you can build relationships with your team.

Decide where to work

- Designate a space that's used solely for work so that you can mentally switch from home to office. Don't have a separate room to use as an office? Consider using a screen or partition to physically divide the space.
- Make sure you have the equipment you need to be productive (for GitLab team members, here's a helpful guide).
- Join a coworking space or meet up with someone else who works remotely to cowork in person.
- Try out different background sounds like music, ambient noise, or silence to see what works best for you while you're working.
- If you have family or roommates at home while you're working, consider setting boundaries with them about your workspace to reduce interruptions.

Create an ergonomic workspace

{style="max-width: 50%;"}

The goal of office ergonomics is to design your workspace so that it fits you and allows for a comfortable working environment for maximum productivity and efficiency.

Since we all work from home, GitLab wants each team member to have the supplies and knowledge they need to create an ergonomic home office.

Here are some tips from the Mayo Clinic on how to arrange your work station.

- Chair: Choose a chair that supports your spinal curves. Adjust the height of your chair so that your feet rest flat on the floor or on a footrest and your thighs are parallel to the floor. Adjust armrests so your arms gently rest on them with your shoulders relaxed.
- Keyboard and mouse: Place your mouse within easy reach and on the same surface as your keyboard. While typing or using your mouse, keep your wrists straight, your upper arms close to your body, and your hands at or slightly below the level of your elbows. Use keyboard shortcuts to reduce extended mouse use. If possible, adjust the sensitivity of the mouse so you can use a light touch to operate it. Alternate the hand you use to operate the mouse by moving the mouse to the other side of your keyboard. Keep regularly used objects close to your body to minimize reaching. Stand up to reach anything that can't be comfortably reached while sitting.
- Telephone: If you frequently talk on the phone and type or write at the same time, place your phone on speaker or use a headset rather than cradling the phone between your head and neck.
- Footrest: If your chair is too high for you to rest your feet flat on the floor · or the height of your desk requires you to raise the height of your chair · use a footrest. If a footrest is not available, try using a small stool or a stack of sturdy books instead.
- Desk: Under the desk, make sure there's clearance for your knees, thighs and feet. If the desk is too low and can't be adjusted, place sturdy boards or blocks under the desk legs. If the desk is too high and can't be adjusted, raise your chair. Use a footrest to support your feet as needed. If your desk has a hard edge, pad the edge or use a wrist rest. Don't store items under your desk. GitLab recommends having an adjustable standing desk to avoid any issues.
- Monitor: Place the monitor directly in front of you, about an arm's length away. The top of the screen should be at or slightly below eye level. The monitor should be directly behind your keyboard. If you wear bifocals, lower the monitor an additional 1 to 2 inches for more

comfortable viewing. Place your monitor so that the brightest light source is to the side.

Note: If you develop any pains which you think might be related to your working position, please visit a doctor.

Dedicate time for health and fitness

{{< youtube "HhIqwJsNyM" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (GitLab) and Anna-Karin (Because Mondays) discuss a number of challenges and solutions related to remote work, transitioning a company to remote, working asynchronously, and defaulting to documentation.

It's sometimes hard to remember to stay active when you work from home. Here are some tips that might help:

- Try to step away from your computer and stretch your body every hour.
- If possible, choose a workspace that's exposed to natural light.
- Avoid "Digital Eye Strain" by following the 20-20-20 Rule. Every 20 minutes look into the distance (at least 20 feet/6 meters) for 20 seconds.
- Use an app - there are some that will remind you to take a break or help you with your computer posture:
 - Time Out(macOS)
 - SafeEyes (GNU/Linux)
- Move every day
 - Go for a walk or do a short exercise for at least 15 minutes a day.
 - Do something active that can be done within a short amount of time like rope jumping, lifting kettlebells, push-ups or sit-ups. It might also help to split the activity into multiple shorter sessions. You can use an app that helps you with the workout, e.g., 7 minute workout.

> "Getting out of the house before I start my day is very important for me. Either walking the dog or going for a swim to clear my head and get the blood flowing."
- Daniel Gruesso, Product Manager

- Try to create a repeatable schedule that is consistent and try to make a habit out of it. Make sure you enjoy the activity.
- It can also help to create a goal or challenge for yourself, e.g. registering for a race.
- Eat less refined sugar and simple carbs, and eat complex carbs instead. Try to eat more vegetables. Don't go to the kitchen to eat something every 15 minutes (it's a trap!). Keep junk food out of your house.
- Have a water bottle with you at your desk. You will be more inclined to drink if it's available at all times.
- Try to get enough sleep at night and take a nap during the day if you need one.

At GitLab, we want to ensure each team member takes care of themselves and dedicates time to stay healthy. You can also join the Slack channel fitlab to discuss your tips, challenges, results, etc. with other team members.

Contribute to this page

We recognize that the whole idea of all-remote organizations is still quite new, and can only be successful with active participation from the whole community. Here's how you can participate:

- Propose or suggest any change to this site by creating a merge request.
- Create an issue if you have any questions or if you see an inconsistency.
- Help spread the word about all-remote organizations by sharing it on social media.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/transition.md

On this page, we're detailing considerations for transitioning a colocated or hybrid-remote company to 100% remote, as well as tips for introducing remote team members to a historically in-office organization.

We maintain a separate guide with blueprints and examples on transitioning from a primarily colocated environment to a hybrid-remote environment.

For more, visit GitLab's guide to understanding the phases of remote adaptation.

How do you transition a hybrid team to a fully remote team?

{{< youtube "MSj6-wC4f9w" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (GitLab) and Janice (Groupdesk) discuss the potential of transitioning a hybrid-remote company to all-remote.

In general, a company seeking to transition to fully remote should actively avoid or remove common hybrid-remote pitfalls by whatever means necessary. Moreover, it's important for leaders to put themselves in the shoes of a prospective job seeker who will ask very specific questions to determine how prepared a company is to thrive in a 100% remote setting.

Much of it boils down to changing whatever elements you need in order to become the remote company that you would want to work for. This requires old habits to be left behind, and intentional effort to be made on areas such as documentation, informal communication, and working well asynchronously.

If existing leadership is not equipped to understand these nuances or lead such a transformation, consider recruiting a Head of Remote with deep experience working in remote settings and leading globally distributed teams. Andreas Klinger aptly articulates this role as being "at the intersection of optimizing internal tooling, processes, transparency, collaboration, efficiency, inclusivity, onboarding, hiring, employer-branding, culture and communication overall."

The specific answer to this question will vary from company to company, and will be impacted by

the following attributes.

1. Company size
1. Quantity of offices
1. Percentage of employees who already work remotely
1. Existing tools and technology infrastructure for operating remotely
1. Existing culture surrounding communication and career mapping

Make the executive team remote

The quickest way to send the clearest signal that remote is the future is to start at the top of the organizational chart. Julien Dollen, Director of Engineering at Oracle, explains below.

> If you want remote to work, start by cutting off the head. When the chief is remote, all of a sudden everybody is remote and everybody starts writing down everything. What used to be ephemeral and on a whiteboard became written down and stored. · Julien Dollon, Director of Engineering at Oracle

Cédric Fabianski, co-founder and CTO at Bearer, reiterated that he saw this work well at FreeAgent, too. He notes that by moving the executive suite out of the office, it removes any doubt about leadership's intentions to complete the transition.

Establish a remote infrastructure

{{< youtube "HhlqwJsNyM" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (GitLab) and Anna-Karin (Because Mondays) discuss a number of challenges and solutions related to remote work, transitioning a company to remote, working asynchronously, and defaulting to documentation.

Companies considering a transition to fully remote should ask themselves if they could function if every team member chose to work from their home tomorrow. To get an idea of what needs to be in place from a tools and technology standpoint, consider the following questions in light of the aforesaid scenario.

1. What voids would become apparent?
1. What areas of communication would falter?
1. What confusion would emerge?
1. What tools do we use today that we would continue to use as a fully remote team?
1. What tools that empower fully remote teams should we consider?

Companies that rely on in-office meetings will likely need to embrace a new paradigm, leveraging Zoom and Google Calendar. Too, they should resist the urge to default to meetings, relying instead on asynchronous communication wherever possible.

Enabling access to systems and files across a fully remote company can be very different, and may require a new approach to security.

Document the culture

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If you do not have a living, evolving company handbook, start one now. Embracing the notion of "if it's not documented, it isn't actionable," is key to detaching from colocated norms and positioning for success with all-remote. Manage expectations that this handbook will never be complete, and it may take months or years to even feel comprehensive.

Ideally, updating the handbook with policies and processes is something that the entire company is empowered and encouraged to do. For existing companies who do not have the luxury of starting their handbook as they start their business, consider hiring an arbiter to kickstart its creation and development. Former journalists and documentarians are great candidates for such a role.

Consider each aspect of your company culture that is unwritten or implied, and document each one. In a fully remote setting, there are no daily in-person interactions where cues are absorbed. Hence, it is vital to over-communicate not just in daily work, but in explaining and detailing values that company culture is built upon.

GitLab uses GitLab to build, sustain, and evolve its company handbook. GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at [GitLab's remote team solutions page](#).

Close the office

If at all possible, close the office. Shuttering an office (or multiple offices) offers the clearest signal that you're all-in with remote, and leaders are serious about ensuring that no one is treated · consciously or otherwise · as an outsider.

Equip and educate team members

While remote work is liberating and empowering, it can be jarring and isolating for those who are not equipped to manage the change. In an all-remote or remote-first company, team members are well aware of what to expect even before they apply for a role. In fact, many remote companies receive outsized interest in roles specifically because of their remote nature.

It's vital for leadership to understand that there may be resistance to a remote transition from employees who would prefer not to work remotely, or are anxious about the lifestyle change.

Clear and proactive internal communication is essential to removing fear and instilling excitement about the increased autonomy.

1. Consider building an applicable guide to starting (or moving into) a remote role, akin to GitLab's guide on the topic.

1. Host AMA (Ask Me Anything) sessions to get a better understanding of team member concerns

and perspectives, and use that feedback to shape strategy.

1. Retain workspace consultants to ensure that team members are equipped to work comfortably and ergonomically in their home.

1. Consider a policy that reimburses fees associated with co-working spaces, understanding that some employees will thrive in settings that mimic the office.

1. Invest in education, including conferences, courses, meetups, etc.

1. Formalize and document an in-person strategy, embracing retreats, company summits, etc. to show that bonding in a physical space is still valued.

1. Prepare for micro-groups to form as people relocate. Leverage geographic Slack channels to retain community even as people use newfound remote freedoms to move to a locale that is more personally fulfilling.

1. Get intentional about informal communication. With the removal of daily in-person interactions, you'll need to formalize mechanisms such as coffee chats, team social calls, and co-working calls to form and foster relationships.

Embrace iteration and transparency in transition

{{< youtube "3HHyjAV3hYE?start=581" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (Head of Remote, GitLab) and Gabe (Senior Product Manager, GitLab) talk on the topic of going slow to go fast, as well as the importance of a "handbook-first" approach to company-wide documentation.

> I think documentation has to be instilled as a value. It has to start there, and the whole leadership team in an organization has to be onboard.

>

> All of leadership needs to understand the importance of documentation · not just with lip service. A true, genuine understanding of its value. If they truly understand the value of it, they'll emanate that to their direct reports.

>

> For companies looking to transition to fully remote, a helpful step for leadership is to say: "OK, we're going to be remote-first as a start." This means that a company in transition would optimize everything in its physical office space to be remote-first. Instead of optimizing conference rooms with lots of tables, for instance, you have each employee sit in their own office and wear headsets all day. This is how you prevent remote employees from feeling disconnected and isolated.

>

> This is going slow to go fast. Lots of energy up front · you go slow · but that accelerates things dramatically a year or so down the road. · Gabe W., Senior Product Manager, GitLab

Expect bumps along the road. As with any significant business transformation, it's wise to communicate proactively to team members, customers, and investors that obstacles will emerge. Transitioning a company to fully remote, while still running the business, is not easy. It's a long-term bet that the short-term pain will be worthwhile.

Leadership should be completely transparent with team members as the transition unfolds. Share headaches and roadblocks as well as successes. This should occur in an agreed channel so that discussion and feedback is centralized, and action items can be clearly disseminated.

Iteration is a core value at GitLab, and we strive to apply iteration to everything · from

building a product to shaping our workspaces. This applies to business transformation as well. Implement the smallest valuable change, solicit feedback, and tweak or revert if needed. By taking this approach to transforming your business, you're setting the example for how day-to-day tasks should be managed in a fully remote setting.

Iteration requires empowered teams and workers

The cost of cross-team coordination is difficult to track; in many enterprises, this leads to delays and cost overruns. A sudden remote transition is an opportunity to address always-evolving policies for new applications, procurements, projects, and/or vendors.

The ability to charge forward and deliver capabilities is a combination of a few key activities:

- Open source software to reduce code written
- Dynamically provisioned environments
- Freedom to experiment without consensus
- Monitoring and clean-up to manage resources and costs

Attempting to transition to a remote working environment while maintaining the gatekeeping effects of the system administrators and security teams may hinder aspirational values such as bias for action. Do not provide access to sensitive data sets or applications to unverified vendors or take any unnecessarily risky approaches, but try to shrink guard rails and take inventory of what is truly sensitive and/or confidential.

Leadership must foster creativity and intentionally seek progressive, two-way door approaches. Once a technique or application is proving itself out in the experimental phase, mature it with security evaluations and reliability. Importantly, any experiments that don't pan out won't have wasted months or years.

Hiring a Head of Remote Work

Organizations should consider hiring a Head of Remote Work. This may be titled Director of Remote Work, VP of Remote Work, Chief Remote Officer, or a variety of alternatives. Longer-term, this role may evolve into a Head of Workplace Experience, Head of Culture, or similar. Below is a series of fundamental questions that leaders must answer when transitioning to remote. It is unlikely that an existing team will be capable of directing adequate attention to these needs without backfilling for other responsibilities.

Finding a leader with extensive remote experience and a history of successful business or culture transformations will be difficult. Suddenly-remote companies may consider hiring a Chief Documentarian to establish a regimented documentation strategy, and morph this role into a more encompassing one over time. Former editors and publishers may be suitable for such a role.

A sample of questions to be answered by a Head of Remote Work:

1. Who will be responsible for ensuring that newly-remote workers have healthy, ergonomic workspaces at home?
1. Who will sit down and audit every single perk and benefit offered globally, and ensure that

remote workers have equivalent benefits to those who choose to work onsite?

1. Who will lead an end-to-end tools audit, ensuring that tools which do not support asynchronous workflows are deprecated or replaced, and ensuring that existing tools are used in remote-first ways?
1. Who will create, establish, and champion your firm's documentation strategy, hiring the right team to ensure that communication voids are closed?
1. Who will coach your executives on the nuanced benefits of one or more being remote by default, sending clear signals that praise and promotion are not tied to a physical building?
1. Who will be the voice of the distributed worker, ensuring equality and belonging for those who may never step foot in a corporate office?
1. Who will ensure that learning and development principles address the challenges of remote hiring, remote interviewing, remote onboarding, remote management, remote promotions, and beyond?
1. Who will conduct an end-to-end process audit and provide structured replacements for remote-last workflows, such as a reliance on synchronous meetings for consensus gathering and collaboration?
1. Who will lead the reevaluation of company values, and subsequent editing and bolstering such that everyone understands how to treat others without the need for routine in-person contact?
1. Who will put a travel strategy in place such that in-person engagements become a core part of building company culture?
1. Who will revise your company's talent acquisition strategy, creating a clear and concise answer to "What's your stance on workplace flexibility?"
1. Who will build a visible talent brand demonstrating how remote workers are supported and included? (This will create significant sway in your Glassdoor reviews.)
1. Who will lead existing executives in transforming their expectations and ways of working, coaching them to model the unlearning of old habits and embracing new ones in transparent fashion?
1. Who will ensure that teams have the tools, direction, and coaching they need to become documentarians?
1. Who will outline a multi-year remote transformation strategy with quarterly milestones and objectives, coaching a team through iterative change and celebrating small wins along the way?
1. Who will champion your culture and values, not only to galvanize teams through a pandemic, but excite them by building a more disciplined, cohesive, asynchronous, inclusive, and diverse future?
1. Who will understand the nuances of remote and the myriad business implications beyond just today?

Transitioning to remote work is not a binary switch that is flipped. While many organizations were thrust into their homes overnight, that is only the first of many steps. Remote is a journey of iteration - a tireless, evolving trek that demands a leader, or else your firm risks falling back into conventional habits or creating a fractured culture where no one is clear on what is expected.

The larger your organization is, or the more deeply it is entrenched in colocated tradition, the more significant the challenge and compensation expectations. This role will be far more complex in a hybrid-remote setting compared to an all-remote setting, as you're answering every question twice.

Adding remote employees to a primarily in-office culture

{style="max-width: 50%;"}</p></div>
<div data-bbox="114 121 923 171" data-label="Text">
<p>While GitLab believes that all-remote is the best structure to ensure that our values are lived and no one is treated as a second-class team member, the reality is that most companies formed to date have at least one physical office.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 187 853 238" data-label="Text">
<p>In many instances, it is not feasible to transition entirely to all-remote, though leaders and recruiters are starting to realize that remote work is the future. Stripe, for example, has stated that its "fifth engineering hub is remote."</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 254 883 337" data-label="Text">
<p>> Stripe has engineering hubs in San Francisco, Seattle, Dublin, and Singapore. We are establishing a fifth hub that is less traditional but no less important: Remote. We are doing this to situate product development closer to our customers, improve our ability to tap the 99.74% of talented engineers living outside the metro areas of our first four hubs, and further our mission of increasing the GDP of the internet. · David S., CTO at Stripe</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 352 755 370" data-label="Text">
<p>Jack Dorsey, CEO at Twitter, has shared that remote is the company's future.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 386 965 535" data-label="Text">
<pre><blockquote class="twitter-tweet tw-align-center"><p lang="en" dir="ltr">The TweepTour is over! 27 offices visited around the world, our last visit being our future: remote. So many stories, so many amazing folks. Thank you all! oneteam ·</p>— jack ··· (@jack) October 30, 2019</blockquote> <script async src="https://platform.twitter.com/widgets.js" charset="utf-8"></script></pre>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 552 959 635" data-label="Text">
<p>In instances where a company intends to maintain at least one physical office, but will allow remote hires for certain roles, added care must be taken. There is effectively nothing that can be done to completely remove bias that comes from seeing someone in the same physical space day after day, so leadership must be intentional about considering remote employees for input, feedback, promotion, and mentorship.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 650 920 702" data-label="Text">
<p>Added care must be taken to ensure that the usual downsides of hybrid-remote are not tolerated. Conversely, employees considering a hybrid-remote role must be prepared to gracefully manage said challenges should they arise.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 717 902 767" data-label="Text">
<p>Above all, a company which intends to begin hiring remotely (or allowing existing employees to optionally transition from colocated to remote) must structure the company as if every single team member were remote.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 783 946 851" data-label="Text">
<p>This means that any hallway conversations must be documented and disseminated for all who were not present to hear, and it means that in-office workers must each use a single webcam and microphone to join a group call (as opposed to in-office colleagues gathering in a conference room with a sole camera).</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 866 922 901" data-label="Text">
<p>It means, for example, that colleagues who are sitting side-by-side must use a public Slack channel to communicate, as vocalizing a conversation would be unfair to team members who are</p>
</div>

remote.

This requires tremendous effort, day after day, from every member of the company.

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Transitioning a Company to Remote

Anyone can test their knowledge on Transitioning a Company to Remote by completing the knowledge assessment. Earn at least an 80% or higher on the assessment to receive a passing score. Once the quiz has been passed, you will receive an email acknowledging the completion from GitLab. We are in the process of designing a GitLab Remote Certification and completion of the assessment will be one requirement in obtaining the certification. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

Making remote work well, particularly in companies with colocated roots, is a shared challenge. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/what-not-to-do.md

Due to global issues concerning Coronavirus (COVID-19), rising rents in concentrated urban areas, and the ongoing battle amongst organizations for recruiting and retaining top talent, there has been a noted shift in appetite for working remotely. Companies which were previously against remote work are suddenly considering remote, or implementing remote, with varying degrees of intentionality.

The reality is that almost every company is already a remote company. If you have more than one office, operate a company across more than one floor in a building, or conduct work while traveling, you are a remote company. It behooves all of these firms to adopt remote-first practices, even if some interactions occur in a shared physical space.

On this page, we're detailing what not to do when transitioning to remote, or moving towards remote.

Do not assume that there are no resources available yet

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GitLab has created a comprehensive guide to working well remotely, covering popular topics such as:

1. Transitioning to remote

1. Forcing functions to work remote-first
1. Hybrid-remote pitfalls to avoid
1. Phases of remote adaptation
1. Meetings
1. Management
1. Scaling
1. Informal communication
1. Building culture
1. Combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety
1. Embracing asynchronous workflows
1. Remote workspaces
1. Getting started in a remote role

The pages within, just like the entire GitLab handbook, are publicly accessible. Please consider studying these guides, implementing them, and contributing your learnings to make them better.

Do not replicate the in-office/colocated experience, remotely

It is vital to recognize and appreciate this point: an organization should not attempt to merely replicate the in-office/colocated experience, remotely.

Remote work is not traditional work which is simply conducted in a home office instead of a company office. There is a natural inclination for those who have not personally experienced remote work to assume that the core (or only) difference between in-office work and remote work is location (in-office vs. out-of-office). This is inaccurate, and if not recognized, can be damaging to the entire practice of working remotely.

The principles of remote work are different. The approach to conducting work is different. Just as multi-level office buildings required elevators and phones to be functional as workplaces, teams working remotely should embrace tools (GitLab, Figma, etc.) that enable asynchronous communication and should reconsider traditional thoughts on items such as meetings and informal communication.

Do not transfer all in-person meetings to virtual

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Remote work isn't something you do as a reaction to an event · it is an intentional approach to work that creates greater efficiency, more geographically and culturally diverse teams, and heightened transparency.

What is happening en masse related to Coronavirus (COVID-19) is largely a temporary work-from-home phenomenon, where organizations are not putting remote work ideals into place, as they expect to eventually require their team members to resume commuting into an office.

Merely transferring planned office meetings to virtual meetings misses an opportunity to answer a fundamental question: is there a better way to work than to have a meeting in the first place?

Do not assume that everyone has access to an optimal workspace

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While long-term remote workers have had years to tweak and iterate on their home office, those who are thrust into working from anywhere may be ill-prepared. Organizations should not expect team members to be masters in office design and ergonomics. Too, what works best for one person will look different than another person.

If transitioning to remote, organizations should empower team members to spend company money as if it is their own when constructing a home office. Consider reimbursing expenses related to coworking spaces and external offices, as some team members will prefer to work outside of their homes.

Do this, not that

Some may find it useful to see examples of comparisons between colocated norms, and the most closely correlated remote recommendation. You will notice that many suggestions link back to asynchronous workflows, transparency, and working handbook-first, which are cornerstones to doing remote well.

Note that all of these suggestions are not exclusive to remote. Even for companies which intend to maintain offices or transition to a hybrid-remote company, implementing remote-first techniques ensure that all employees are viewed as first-class citizens and companies avoid the five dysfunctions of a team.

- Sending an email or Slack message <> Leverage a transparent, asynchronous communications tool
- Scheduling a meeting <> Communicate asynchronously
- Gathering executives in a shared physical space <> Model commitment to remote by getting the executive team out of the office
- Grappling with a large project <> Breaking discussions down into their smallest, most minimally viable parts
- Gathering consensus for a one-way door decision <> Break decisions down into a series of smaller, two-way door decisions which can be iterated upon and reverted
- Sharing updates verbally <> Write things down with detail and precision, in a low-context manner
- Expecting an immediate response <> Approach your work as if everyone else is asleep, and work to create a non-judgmental culture

Do not assume that remote happens overnight

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For companies who move into an office building, it's unlikely that everything works perfectly on the first day. Signage may be missing, security gates may be erratic, elevators may be stuck, etc. Adapting to a workplace takes time, and polish comes with iteration.

The same is true when embracing remote work. Particularly for companies which were established

with colocated norms, it is vital for leadership to recognize that the remote transition is a process, not a binary switch to be flipped. Leaders are responsible for embracing iteration, being open about what is and is not working, and messaging this to all employees.

Remote isn't a structure that merely works or doesn't work. Remote is a way of working that requires intentional and perpetual care and evaluation · just as you'd expect in an office environment. Working well remotely (or in-office, for that matter) is not something that is ever done or accomplished. There are always new tools to consider, new workflows to integrate, and new expertise to ingest.

Too, what works for a small remote team may not work for a remote team consisting of thousands of team members. All of this is equally true for colocated companies, though it tends to be less amenable to Band-aid (temporary) solutions in a remote environment.

Do not assume that remote management is drastically different

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In truth, managing a remote company is much like managing any company. It comes down to trust, communication, and company-wide support of shared goals, all of which aid in avoiding dysfunction.

Remote forces you to do the things you should be doing way earlier and better. It forces discipline that sustains culture and efficiency at scale, particularly in areas which are easily deprioritized in small colocated companies.

It's important to not assume that team members understand good remote work practices. GitLab managers are expected to coach their reports to utilize asynchronous communication, be handbook-first, design an optimal workspace, and understand the importance of self-learning/self-service.

Leaders should ensure that new remote hires read a getting started guide, and make themselves available to answer questions throughout one's journey with the company.

Do not assume your existing values can remain static

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To operate well as a remote enterprise, your values must be in support of this way of working. GitLab's collection of values and operating principles contribute to a thriving all-remote environment. Consider studying the nuances of these values and adjusting or adding to your company's existing values. Values that were established to support colocated norms may not apply to remote, particularly those which obstruct transparency.

Don't be quick to brush values off as understood, either. For example, collaboration in a colocated space is routinely demonstrated by gathering people in a shared physical space in search of consensus. Collaboration in a remote setting is demonstrated by empowering the greatest amount of people to contribute insights asynchronously while enabling the DRI

(directly responsible individual) to make decisions without explanation.

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{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}
```

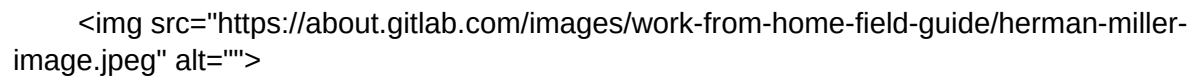
Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

Return to the main all-remote page.

```
## SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/work-from-home-field-guide.md
```

```
<div class="container">
<div class="row align-items-center">
  <div class="col">
    <p class="lead">Leaders and employers who want to create equitable and inclusive
    experiences for their diverse team need to support work wherever it happens. Today, that could
    be a home office, a coworking space, or even on the go. This shift toward remote work has been
    germinating for years, but the Covid-19 pandemic rapidly accelerated its widespread adoption.
    Now that remote work is here to stay, how can business leaders help their organizations
    navigate it?</p>
    <p class="lead">This field guide is your blueprint.</p>
    <p class="lead">Find out more <a href="">about remote work</a> or <a
    href="https://about.gitlab.com/resources/downloads/remote-work-report-2021.pdf" class="btn btn-
    primary">Download the Full Report</a>
  </div>
  <div class="col text-center">
    
  </div>
</div>
<hr>
<div class="container">
<div class="row align-items-center">
  <div class="col">
    <h2 class="h1 my-4">Project background</h2>
    <p class="h3">GitLab is pleased to co-create this field guide with Herman Miller,
    combining <a href="guide/">GitLab's expertise on remote teams</a> and best practices with
    Herman Miller's deep understanding of workspaces and design.</a>
  </div>
  <div class="col text-center">
```



Key Takeaways

It starts with leadership

Whether your organization is hybrid or fully remote, it's up to company leaders to support all aspects of the employee experience. Just as you'd invest in your team's workspace in a co-located office, enabling them to create healthy, productive spaces outside the office is a core part of building your remote work infrastructure..

Work is where the worker is

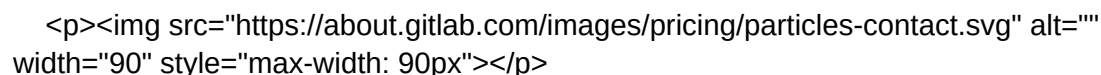
We have many choices for where to work on a given day: your home office or kitchen counter, a coffee shop, a coworking space, even a car or plane. No matter where work gets done, it's important to be intentional about how you use these spaces.

Inclusive spaces help bolster belonging

Leaders who want to attract and retain a talented, diverse team will need to cultivate a work environment that is inclusive of needs and preferences. When done intentionally, a workplace strategy that embraces remote or hybrid work can be a differentiator for your team.

One size does not fit all

Each of your team members will have different equipment needs, space limitations, and location preferences for getting work done. The key is providing them the autonomy and agency to make these decisions for themselves, being open to feedback, and creating a culture of iteration.



Improve remote work for you and your team

[Get the Work-from-Home Field Guide](https://about.gitlab.com/resources/downloads/Work-from-Home%20Field%20Guide.pdf)

Learn more about remote work

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{{% include "includes/take-gitlab-for-a-spin.md" %}}

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/working-while-traveling.md

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On this page, we're detailing considerations for optimizing comfort and efficiency when taking your office with you while traveling.

Connect to the Internet securely

When possible, do not connect to public WiFi networks. If a public WiFi network is your only option, it's crucial to employ robust security measures such as using a personal VPN.

Additionally, GitLab team members should be wary of connecting to unsecured networks or accessing sensitive information over public connections, even when using a VPN. When Ethernet connections are available, they generally offer a more secure option than WiFi due to their physical nature, but it's still essential to verify the network's authenticity and utilize encryption protocols whenever possible.

Internet redundancy

{{% cardpane %}}
{{% card footer="A smartphone with tethering enabled is vital for digital nomads. Photo by Darren Murph" %}}

{{% /card %}}
{{% /cardpane %}}

For remote workers, a robust connection to the internet is vital. This is easier to control at home or in a coworking venue, and it requires special consideration when on the road. Avid travelers should maintain at least two connectivity sources - ideally, two sources that connect to different mobile networks.

A simple way to achieve this redundancy is to lean on one mobile network operator for your smartphone (and enable tethering if it is not on by default with your current plan), while procuring a mobile hotspot through a different operator.

Another way to improve your chances of a strong internet connection while traveling is to bring an Ethernet cord and adapter that allows you to connect an ethernet cord to your laptop. Not all hotels or coworking spaces will provide an ethernet connection option, but if it is available Ethernet is your best bet for a fast, secure internet connection.

If you plan to travel through various countries and continents, plan ahead. Services such as KnowRoaming and Skyroam enable connections across borders. While it's possible to acquire a local SIM card in most countries, you'll need an unlocked smartphone or hotspot. Plus, you may

need a basic understanding of the local language, local currency, and to shop during regular business hours.

Buy local data with an eSIM, without changing your SIM card

If your phone supports eSIMs you may also be able to use services like GigSky or Airalo which allow you to purchase affordable local data plans on demand without needing to change SIM cards. Even if you don't purchase the plan you can use such a service as a redundant option if your local or roaming SIM is not getting reliable service.

Some tips for using Airalo:

- Purchase your eSIM before you travel and be sure to activate it while connected to WiFi.
- Have another phone handy so that you can take a picture of the QR code needed to activate your eSIM. This way you can scan it with the phone you're using with the eSIM.
- On the screen where your QR code appears, open the link to the activation instructions. There may be an additional step required to activate the eSIM which involves updating your APN information. This might not appear in the general activation instructions in Airalo's FAQs because it is specific to the eSIM you purchased.

Equipment and ergonomics

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Working while traveling requires a delicate balance. It's wise to have a minimalist mindset when it comes to equipment, as each additional item creates additional burden in transit.

However, long-term travelers should consider health, ergonomics, and comfort, and invest in the appropriate equipment. Examples include laptop risers, global power adapters, external peripherals (keyboard, mouse, etc.), a backup battery, comfortable headphones, and a rugged backpack with support straps. Secondary displays add weight but may be worthwhile for the productivity gains.

Consider where you plan to work on the road, and what elements of your home workspace you may miss. This will help you plan your purchases, should any be necessary.

Learn more about traveling workspaces from the GitLab blog.

RV/camping, long-term rentals, and couch-surfing

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{{% card footer="Working from the ends of the earth is a major perk of all-remote. Photo by Darren Murph" %}}

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Being able to work from anywhere enables new lifestyle possibilities, including extended road

trips in an RV/camper. Those considering such a lifestyle should peruse online forums to understand the day-to-day demands, and take care to plot out your journey in way that doesn't leave you scrambling for a connection.

Call campgrounds in advance and ask for speed test details on their WiFi, and use online coverage maps to determine what will be available from a mobile operator. Consider weather and facilities as well.

For those looking for a somewhat more stable version of the continual road trip, consider long-term rentals or couchsurfing. Many rental properties on VRBO, Airbnb, etc. offer significant discounts for those willing to rent for one or more months. If you suspect you'll need a vehicle to properly explore the area, inquire with the host. It's possible that they have a personal vehicle to include for the length of your stay for a nominal fee. Be sure to ask for a speed test before booking to ensure that you will have a satisfactory internet connection upon arrival, and take at least one additional internet source (smartphone or mobile hotspot) as a backup.

Communicate your status and location

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{{% card footer="Working at GitLab Commit London 2019" %}}
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{{% /cardpane %}}
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The beauty of asynchronous communication is that you're able to travel more freely without the burden of needing to be online at a specific time. When you take your office on the road (or to the skies), keep your Slack status updated with your location, time zone, and expected working hours. This enables team members around the globe to easily recognize where you're at, and respect shifting work hours.

At GitLab, and other companies using Google Apps, your coworkers, trying to schedule meetings or interviews with you, will rely on Google calendar as the source of truth for your availability. As such it is important that your working hours are set and your timezone is updated as soon as possible. It's best to do this before boarding a flight as it gives people scheduling more notice. Unfortunately, there is no way to schedule a timezone change ahead of time in Google calendar. There may be times when you need to reject a calendar invite ahead of time due to your working hours changing. An option to alleviate this issue is to add a blocking calendar event during times when you won't be working while traveling and this can signal clearly to the coworkers when you will be working by looking at the unblocked times.

Connect with locals

At GitLab, our Visiting Grant partially reimburses travel when one team member travels to visit another. In an all-remote setting, this encouragement is important. It sends a message that we should seek out opportunities to spend face-to-face time with colleagues when we travel.

For those in other remote companies, consider asking if there are colleagues located in areas

where you intend to travel. If not, engage with local coworking spaces in order to build community and seek advice on the areas where you're traveling.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

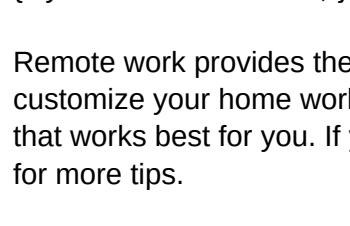
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Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/workspace.md

Why is your home office setup so important?

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Remote work provides the flexibility to work from anywhere. For many people, that means you can customize your home workspace to your unique needs. It's important to configure a remote setup that works best for you. If you're just getting started in a remote role, check out this guide for more tips.

What is the best way to design a work from home setup?

Setting up a home office can be difficult. Many office spaces hire design professionals to create the workspace, but that burden shifts to employees in a remote environment.

While there are benefits to ditching the cubicle, it can feel overwhelming to design a new workspace. It's not as hard as you think to create a space where you can be comfortable, focused, and productive.

Workspace expert Ryan Anderson from MillerKnoll shares how to set up a personal workspace using best practices for ergonomics, productivity, and environment.

{{< youtube "l9jmb8TE7sw" >}}

Like Ryan says, it's important to view your home office as an evolving project. Iteration applies to workspaces, too. As you begin working in your office, you may realize that you need to shift your monitors, add lighting, or find that you get more done in silence or ambient noise than wearing headphones playing music.

GitLab teamed up with the workplace design experts at Herman Miller to create the Work-From-Home Field Guide. This resource is a blueprint for leaders and remote teams to build healthier

workspaces, no matter where work gets done. On this page, we're sharing lessons from that guide, with a lot of added detail.

The importance of choosing the right workspace equipment

Setting up a home office requires two types of equipment: technology and furniture. Budget, physical space, accessibility, or any number of other factors may limit your ability to find the gear that will serve you best. Plus, you'll probably look for equipment that suits your taste.

While we can't answer every equipment question for you, here's an in-depth guide to what some of our workplace experts are using in their own home offices.

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What technology do I need for remote working?

Internet connection

Since remote workers are responsible for internet connectivity, invest in a substantial home internet connection. You may also want to have a backup in case your connection fails - for example, you could upgrade your smartphone/plan to support tethering or invest in a dedicated mobile hotspot or MiFi.

Assuming you're lucky enough to have excellent access, you may also want to set up a secondary connection so there's enough bandwidth for everyone working from your location. One person uploading a large file could impact the audio or visual quality of another person's video